

The Non-Essential Space in Manga

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Abstract: This essay examines imagery in manga that diverges from the medium's temporal traditions and instead employs a compositional logic that is purely spatial. I define these exceptions as the *non-essential space* in manga. This non-essential space employs an alternative temporality, which I call the *material time*, wherein the depiction of time centers on the viewer's interaction with the pictorial elements' materiality. By employing material time, non-essential space can enclose and preserve time, converting itself into an object-like, textured entity whose composition equates to an occupation of space.

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Introduction

Art historian David Joselit describes painting as a “time-battery,” suggesting the appreciation of painting is fundamentally slow, powered by the medium’s unlimited potential for viewing.¹ Therefore, one does not simply look at a painting, but rather stares at it, often in a state of quietude in which the passing of time goes seemingly unnoticed. The consumption of manga, on the other hand, is characterized by its high velocity—divided into short chapters, driven by fast-paced plots, and illustrated with either an economy of marks or overly complicated background drawings whose aesthetic value lies not in their abundant details but rather their occupation of banal space. The rapid appreciation of manga is also evident in the language used to describe it. Although sharing similar aesthetic traditions with pictorial paintings, the consumption of manga is often described as a process of “reading” rather than “looking.” While one often looks intuitively with a vision that wanders around, one reads to absorb information linearly, suggesting the medium specificity of manga revolves around the notion of a singular direction.

Therefore, manga is fundamentally sequential, where each page acts as an interface that connects what comes before and after, facilitating a continuous temporality. The interstitial status of the manga book page is enabled through composition, where the tactical use of frames, text, and blank spaces creates an order of viewing that directs the viewer’s attention smoothly across pages to accelerate the reading speed. Cultural theorist Otsuka Eiji suggests that the successful illustration of a work of manga is more concerned with its editing than with its drawing processes.² Individual frames’ pictorial significance is undermined by their association with an intertwining network of fast images that compensate each other to enhance the experience of reading.³ The

composition strategy in manga, especially the use of frames, is also associated with the traditions of cinema. As suggested by Otsuka, in the 1930s and the early 1940s, Sergei Eisenstein's theory of montage and Western animation films were first introduced to Japanese society; manga artists started to employ a cinematic style of drawing and treated manga frames as if they were frames in film.⁴

Hence, one faces the danger of misidentifying manga as a sub-genre of art or even of cinematography, where its reliance on linear temporality and fast-paced nature deprives the medium of the potential to undergo close examination or to simply "stay around" in the world of art. However, there exist exceptions in manga that diverge from the medium's temporal traditions and employ a compositional logic that is purely spatial. I define these exceptions as the *non-essential space* in manga. Non-essential refers here to the medium of manga because these exceptions do not contribute to its narrative logic. They are also non-essential because they oppose the inherent essentiality of manga, as from *gekiga* to *akabon* to *shôjo* manga, manga has been historically linked with social commentary and entertainment, permeating "every crevice of the contemporary environment."⁵

The scholarship of manga studies has proposed alternative conceptions of manga's temporality in relation to this interstitial space. Natsume Fusanosuke briefly mentions that this atemporal space is primarily employed in *shôjo* manga, a genre aimed at teenage girls, where it often depicts the open-ended psychological space of the protagonist.⁶ Takahashi Mizuki similarly references *shôjo* manga's employment of such space as she cites Ishinomori Shotaro's "spatialization technique" that breaks the linear progression of panels by turning them into decorative devices.⁷ Jaqueline Berndt, in her examination of Mizuki Shigeru's *yokai* manga, also discusses a space with a prolonged

temporality echoing the traditional East Asian “ki-sho-ten-ketsu” narrative structure.⁸ Referring to manga’s cinematism, Deborah Shamoon refers to this halted moment by relating it to the cinematic technique “pillow shot”, where the linear plot is disturbed by a “static view of scenery.”⁹

However, these conceptions either primarily focus on sub-genres within manga and deem this space altogether atemporal, or differentiate it only on account of its divergent tempo compared to others, while still observing the medium’s sequential logic. Building on previous discussions in manga studies, this paper not only argues that the non-essential space is a sub-category with limited applications, but also that it calls for a re-examination of the medium’s visual structure and relationship with time, potentially relieving manga from its functionalities and, subsequently, its awkward state as a sub-genre. Natsume identifies three temporalities in manga: the linear temporality of the narrative, the temporality of the spectator, and the depiction of memory.¹⁰ The non-essential space, rather than existing outside of time, employs an alternative temporality—what I term *material time*—in which the depiction of time centers on the viewer’s interaction with the pictorial elements’ materiality. By employing material time, the non-essential space can enclose and preserve time, converting itself into an object-like, textured entity whose composition equates to an occupation of space. This approach does not eliminate a temporal mode of analysis but instead reworks the current discourse on manga’s temporality.

This essay examines the non-essential space through the three elements that constitute it: blank space, frame, and text. These elements are analyzed according to their construction and ontological status to demonstrate how their use in the non-essential space disrupts the linear temporality of manga through acts of object-making.

To understand how non-essential space differs from traditional image-making practices, examples from both historical and contemporary aesthetic traditions that inform the practice of manga are analyzed, illustrating how the non-essential space is both influenced by and distinct from these traditions. Adopting the methods of close reading and formal analysis, which focus on the syntax and medium specificity of manga imagery, this study first examines the construction of blank space and its two statuses in the canon of manga (as background and as architectural extension) and how it assumes an object-like status by presenting itself as an ornament in the non-essential space. It then discusses the three uses of frame in traditional manga—as an orientational structure, a signifier of attention, and a focusing device—and how the framed image in the non-essential space challenges these canons as it gains physical materiality through texture. Lastly, it analyzes the uses of text as dialogue, narration, and sound in manga, and it discusses how text overcomes its marginal status through the act of sound production. Together, these three elements possess a certain materiality that offers an alternative conception of time and new possibilities for reading and knowledge production, as the reader’s interaction with them centers on the physical act of touch.

Blank Space and Its Construction

The use of blank space is not only prominent in manga but also deeply rooted in the aesthetic traditions of East Asian pictorial practices. Japanese poet and painter Takehisa Yumeji characterized the blank space in Japanese paintings as having the effect of “giving room for [the] imagination of the viewers.”¹¹ In this sense, blank space is constructed upon an intricate balance between the act of removal and expansion, where an implied pictorial plane with abundant details is made possible through processes of

exclusion. In fact, the use of blank space in East Asian pictorial practices is often seen as an expression of artistic taste, as such space indicates a notion of fruitfulness that is not readily available to the viewer and therefore challenges its audience to make intellectual associations. Ma Yuan's painting *Solitary Angler on a Wintry Lake*, for example, depicts a lone angler fishing on a lake at the center of the picture plane; the rest of the paper is left blank. The viewer can imagine the existence of depth, turbulent water, and traces of fish moving underneath the lake surface, thanks to subtle hints left by the artist, such as the curved fishing line and the extended rhythms of the waves. Wu Hong takes this notion of association further in his reading of the spatiality of Chinese paintings, where he suggests the implied spatiality is not only pictorial but also architectural. Wu contends that paintings depicting large blank spaces often act as a physical extension of architectural surroundings and were installed to emphasize the forms within their installation site.¹² In manga, Natsume defines the blank space between frames as *mahaku* (間白), which translates to "the whiteness in between." The term "間," which refers to the separation in space, is also commonly used to address the blank space in the studies of Chinese painting in Japan.¹³ Natsume argues that *mahaku* is often employed to imply transitions in space and time between individual frames, suggesting that the blank space in manga indicates not only a pictorial and architectural extension, but also an extension in time as it rearranges fragmented temporalities into a cohesive body of narrative.¹⁴

Although blank space is treated historically in East Asian pictorial practices as an extended space constructed through its potential for associations, the discussion of blank space in the contemporary art world often revolves around the notion of removal

and refusal. Anna Dezeuze defines blank space as a “monochrome space” established through the exclusion “of the illusionistic, perspectival space of representation,” where the art object is dissolved “into the mundane space of the everyday.”¹⁵ John Cage’s musical composition *4’33”* is an example of the use of monochrome space: Cage instructs the performers not to produce any sound for the duration of the performance. By doing so, the piece occupies a space-time dedicated to an art performance with utter silence, challenging the seemingly crucial difference between art and banal reality. Hence, blank space refuses associations altogether through the disintegration of forms in which the pictorial plane is no longer a “self-contained and unified formal whole,”¹⁶ but rather a mundane, non-representative object that exists at the “threshold of imperceptibility”¹⁷ to question the spectacular status of the art object. The treatment of blank space as a banal and non-representative device is also evident in manga. The historical and social positioning of manga suggests that the medium is often perceived as a form of “border art,” one that can “transgress the boundaries of low and high culture,”¹⁸ and thus never entirely distinguishes itself from everyday life. Natsume also addresses the non-representativeness of manga, suggesting that mahaku is often employed in shōjo manga not as a temporal device that represents a cohesive narrative, but rather as a purely pictorial element that advocates for “blankness itself.”¹⁹ Since shōjo manga often puts greater emphasis on the depiction of emotions than on fast-paced plots, mahaku serves to depict the characters’ nuanced psychological spaces, evoking a sense of stillness and melancholy.

Space-Building in the Non-Essential Space

After examining how blank space is generally conceived in traditional and contemporary artistic practices, the following section discusses how the construction of blank space in the non-essential space builds on and differs from these traditions. Blank space in the non-essential space is structured, supported by invisible internal architectures that carefully withhold elements to denote their status. The structure of the blank space is also delimited by the physical book page, suggesting that, unlike traditional Chinese and Japanese paintings whose canvas size is disproportionately larger than the subject, the blank space's borders are blatant, and its implied motions tend to direct inward rather than expand into its environment. Hence, one must examine the principles of composition in this space to make sense of the construction of its internal architecture.

The construction of blank space in the non-essential space takes the notion of the extended space in East Asian paintings further, where it not only invites the spectator to make associations but also acts as a field that calls for activation, or what Mira Schenden calls “an active void.”²⁰ Imagining blank space as a field, much like a physical field, allows one to emphasize placement rather than direction, suggesting that the compositional logic in this space is not linear but simultaneous, unlike in traditional manga, where a linear temporality directs elements. The field model of blank space also points to an alternative timeline for its composition, where blank space comes before the elements placed within it. In contrast, in the canon of manga's compositional logic, blank space is often realized as a “left-out” space or an aftermath of composition where its shape is determined after the positioning of internal elements. This alternative timeline is perhaps inherited from traditional Chinese paintings. As Charles F. Kelley describes, the landscape in Chinese paintings is not a background but “nature

itself...within which the actions of men might take place” and blank space as a “positive factor” and “never a mere vacancy.”²¹ In line with this, within manga, the significance of blank space therefore lies not in its ability to represent space but rather in its potential for holding.

Therefore, one could equate the process of composition in the blank space to an act of physical space-building, in which its construction is not related to internal elements but instead the magical making visible of its internal architectures through the placement of objects. This process of making visible is spontaneous because space-building concerns not only the principles of composition established over hundreds of years of pictorial practices but also intuition, where one has to decide what makes sense. In his discussion of art in relation to intuition, Martyn Woodward describes the practice of painting as a “form-giving process rather than a representational one” where “the strokes of the brush do not render the visible...but render visible the energies and forces of the form-giving processes...that arise from the relationship between the body, the material, and the environment.”²² Like painting, the space-building process in the non-essential space can make visible the interactional forces inherent to its medium container, upon which forms grow and its internal architecture is established. Therefore, it is crucial to view the composition in the non-essential space not as a realization of finite forms or a process of strategic planning but rather an organic, time-based process of “letting happen.”²³ Although the non-essential space avoids linear temporality in its final form, its relationship with time centers on the histories of movement as elements interact with the field of forces and settle as these forces come into balance.

Status and Functionality of Blank Space

After examining how the blank space came into being, it is useful to discuss its state of being: as background, as architectural extension, and as ornament. In a page in Ishinomori Shotaro's *Jun*, the composition consists of four rectangular frames, with a large frame on the right depicting a figure looking out a window in the rain, and three smaller frames positioned vertically on the left that show details of the figure and the pouring rain, leading to an obscure body of water in the bottom left frame.²⁴ The blank space primarily surrounding these frames serves as the background of the picture plane, lending it gravity and structure while denoting a canonical, uniform materiality for the book page. It is worth noting that this background differs from traditional pictorial compositions: rather than a unified field that implies an ever-expanding pictorial space that transgresses its surface, it operates as a deconstructive device that accentuates the fragmented time-space depicted in each frame. When these frames are read as visual metaphors—for example, the right frame where the character is confined to an unproportionally small window, shadowed by the pouring rain as a metaphor for melancholy—it is obvious how the frames on the left continue this metaphor. As the rain gradually comes to occupy the entire frame, the character's psychological struggle intensifies, culminating in the bottom-left frame where the mass of water suggests powerlessness and surrender. Hence, the blank space unifies these different time-spaces through a metaphorical plane where the frames function as autonomous images interrelated by a process of curation.

Since the frames constitute individual images rather than a unified whole, the blank space can be seen as their site of installation. Following Hong Wu's discussion of the blank space as an extension of the subject's architectural surroundings, blank space can be seen as an architectural extension that emphasizes the pictorial compositions

within the frames. In *Jun*, the blank space forms a narrow border around the individual frames, mirroring the shape of the window in the right frame—depicted as two thin strips of white—and vertically exaggerating the plane to accentuate the downward movement of the rain. It could then be argued that a hierarchy of genre exists where blank space possesses less autonomy than the elements it withholds, as its structure is indexical to and reflective of the elements’ internal compositions, and one’s appreciation of it is innately derivative. This hierarchy also suggests a linear temporality of viewing, since the direction of visual analysis inescapably follows the direction of reflection. Paul Duro addresses the subordinate status of blank space in history paintings, or *historia*, noting that the background, or what is known as the *parergon*, is inherently seen as a “minor genre to actions”.²⁵ However, Duro argues that blank space, apart from being an “architectural surround”, can be read as an “ornamental enclosure” that is “conceptually and materially separate from the picture field.”²⁶ Viewing blank space as an ornament, rather than solely as a relational structure, suggests it possesses an aesthetic value of its own that does not contribute to its usefulness, thus relieving it from its subordinate status. In his analysis of Giotto’s frescos in the Arena Chapel, Thomas Puttfarken also emphasizes the autonomy of ornaments on the picture plane. He claims that Giotto’s scenes are not intended to demonstrate the work’s surface composition but rather their decorative attributes, in which the depicted narrative scenes and the architecture of the fresco serve but one purpose: “human splendor meant to reflect the *lux* of God.”²⁷ Puttfarken’s argument suggests an objecthood for ornament, as it is examined not as a structure but an object that appeals to pure aesthetics and delight. This perspective allows the composition to be seen as Greenberg’s “all-over” picture, where the “equivalent-so” refers to the equivalence of the status of visual elements.²⁸ Therefore,

the blank space in the non-essential space deconstructs the canonical hierarchy of manga composition as it assumes an object-like status through its ornamental reading, dissolving the presumed linear direction of visual analysis and inviting the space to be viewed as an autonomous whole.

Functionality of Frame

To examine the application of frame in the non-essential space, its functions in the canon of manga must first be analyzed. The pictorial frame in manga primarily serves as an orientational device that assumes a center and dimensions for the picture plane, while simultaneously protecting the “play of forces in the picture from...the environment.”²⁹ The influence of traditions in easel paintings is apparent in the early development of manga, where the composition in each frame is not interconnected by a continuous motion but rather independent of its border, employing what Puttfarken calls the “permanency of aspect,” in which all parts of the pictorial plane sustain an unchangeable relationship to each other.³⁰ In Tezuka Osamu’s *The Rainbow Fortress* and *Astro Boy*, for example, the frames are independently composed. The figures are often situated at the center of the rectangular frame with a perspective fixed at eye level, denoting their status as the subject matter. Hence, the frame assumes a stage-like quality undisturbed by adjacent frames, where the fictionality of the work is established through the theatrical staging of actions.

While this recognition of the frame as an orientational device is still prominent in American and European comics today, manga has taken a cinematic turn. Its treatment of the frame started to mimic shots in a film where, alongside showing the spatiality of the setting, the frames also indicate the transition of time. On one hand, scholars such

as Deborah Shamoon, whose work focuses on the genre of gekiga, have analyzed the ways manga mimics cinema, suggesting that the medium adopts an “aspect-to-aspect” approach that echoes the cinematic practice of the “pillow shot” in its depiction of static scenery.³¹ On the other hand, focusing more on linearity, Otsuka cites the use of frame in manga as a “time stamp,”³² whereas Natsume calls it a “semantic unit”³³ whose dimensions indicate the varying quantities of time. Narrower frames, for instance, are employed to denote sudden transitions while wider frames represent slower passages of time. Moreover, the outlines of the figures are not intact but rather cut by the frames, with lines extending beyond the borders. It could then be argued that the frames in contemporary manga are more translucent and mobile, indicating an underlying dynamic that extends in time and space. This suggests that their status as a self-contained stage is transformed into a malleable strip-like facility that represents an attention span. If the frame in traditional pictorial paintings was “a sign of wealth and culture”³⁴ that denoted its value as an art object, the frame in contemporary manga counters this canon by suggesting a loss in the ability to preserve its image, acting as a sign of rapid consumption to be overcome in time.

Frame is also used as a focusing and perspective-shifting device in manga, where it acts as a magnifying facility that denotes the status of certain elements as *details*. In the previously mentioned example of *Jun*, for example, the figure and the patterns of rain are enlarged in the frames on the left, suggesting these elements need more attention than, for example, the texture of the window frame or the darkness of the interior space. Addressing partial elements as details can be seen as an obsolete practice, as it indicates an inherent politics of the picture plane that asks the viewer to devote more attention and care to certain parts of the composition. At the same time, it

suggests the unsatisfactory nature of the “whole image”. The declaration of detail also asks one to focus on the inner relations within a picture plane, while recent discussions of the pictorial practice often center on its post-medium conditions, asking one to see it as “beside itself”.³⁵ However, it is crucial to understand these magnified images not as partial to the “whole image” in the non-essential space but rather as alternative images that serve as a signifier of multiplicity. Regarding the history of East Asian pictorial practices, there exists a tendency to depict a multiplicity in perspective where multiple vanishing points co-exist on a single picture plane. This arbitrary perspective allows the image to be considered beyond its representability of reality and the composition beyond what Kelley calls an act of “modeling,”³⁶ thus diminishing the role of the spectator, as one is unable to assume a single point of spectatorship. Hence, the frame in the non-essential space implies a multitude of visual interpretations capable of surpassing any singular perspectival reading, asking the viewer not to focus on the internal politics of the framed images but rather on their status of co-existence.

Materiality of the Framed Image

It is important to consider not only the functionalities of the frame but also the materiality of the framed image. Louis Marin declares the status of the frame as differential to the image it surrounds by stating “the boundary...does not represent the spectacle as the other parts of the representation represent it...It represents the mimetic relationship the representation has with the spectacle.”³⁷ This suggests that frame possesses an agency separate from its content, where it not only establishes a realm of fictionality but also denotes its content as inherently representational. In the case of manga, since what is outside of the frame is not reality but rather blank space, it could

be argued that the frame distinguishes not only representation from the real world but also attention from non-attention where the bordered image is fundamentally subject to its frame.

However, this analysis reveals a uniform materiality to the framed image where its borders are not metaphoric separations but rather edges whose physical properties are indistinguishable from its body, like the edges of a physical cube. In the non-essential space, the frame clearly obtains an aesthetic and emotional agency that refuses this representative reading and asks one to consider its mass and texture with an odd sense of tenderness. Joselit argues in “Against Representation” that the relationship between representation and the represented centers on spatiality as representation can be equated to an act of “surrounding.”³⁸ In the case of the non-essential space, the frame attaches itself to its body; it serves not to separate but rather to occupy space, allowing itself and the framed image to obtain an object-like status. Natsume describes this object-like status in *Manga no Yomikata* through a membrane model, where the framed images are separated into different layers of membrane by what they depict, such as memory, reality, and the character’s psychological space.³⁹ The membrane model, which is often employed to depict psychological spaces in shōjo manga, suggests a materiality of the framed images as light, translucent, and floating in space. Natsume links this materiality to the group mentality of the Japanese audience in the 1970s as Japan started to transition toward a middle-class society where one’s individuality is intertwined with a larger group identity.⁴⁰

The membranes, however, face the danger of slipping off and falling apart, and at the same time confuse the materiality of the frame with that of the page. The membrane model also suggests that different layers are loosely attached, indicating the existence of

an aperture between them, as accurately demonstrated by an instance in Clamp's *X* where the uppermost panels—shaped as thin circular strips—cast visible shadows onto the bottom layer.⁴¹ These apertures propose a brief yet prevalent temporality of viewing and advocate for a potency directed into the page that is rapidly deconstructed by the act of flipping to the next page. Hence, the membrane model reveals itself as a shallow container that once again falls under manga's tradition of chronicle and rapid consumption.

A page in *Hunter x Hunter* offers an alternative explanation for the materiality of the framed image, showing how it can sustain its spatial agency through *texture*.⁴² The page consists of five framed images. The top and bottom frames repeat the representational traditions in easel painting, placing the figure at the center of the picture plane. The topmost frame also refers to cinematic techniques through the cropping of the face, mimicking a close-up shot where the camera slowly tilts upward to reveal the character.

The dark frame, however, shifts the perspective from the external world to the character's inner spiritual space as the figure disappears. The frame in this case is undifferentiable from its body, which can be seen as an infinite duplication of the frame, both vertically and horizontally, suggesting not only the frame's physicality but also its role as the *texture* of its body. The subsequent narrow frame is more blatant in its depiction of texture, with indented lines that vary in thickness. The notion of texture proposes an enclosed time-space where one's examination of it can equate to an act of touching, thus converting the act of examination from the visual to the haptic. Laura Marks defines this mode of examination as "haptic visuality," where "the way vision itself can be tactile, as though one were touching a film with one's eyes," suggesting that haptic looking tends to "move over the surface of its object rather than to plunge into

illusionistic depth.”⁴³ Kathy O’Dell proposes an inherent relationship between the frame and the haptic perception of art, claiming that the act of touching inescapably concludes with one’s realization of the edges of the object’s physical container, where “these edges demarcate the spatial and temporal distinction at the base of all representation – the distinction between here and there, now and then”⁴⁴. Hence, the frame in the non-essential space presents itself as a material conclusion that does not instigate a direction but instead suggests a material entity in time and space that the act of reading cannot surpass.

Functionality of Text

Text in manga primarily exists in three forms: dialogue, narration, and sound. Unlike blank space and frame, text operates more as an action than a structure, as it often assumes a voice that advocates for autonomy. Therefore, to examine the construction of text, one must first question: who produces these texts? Dialogue is spoken by the characters themselves, while narration can come from either an omniscient spectator (often assumed to be the author) or the inner voice of a character. Narrative text is usually placed at the side of the image and often provides explanation and commentary. The previously mentioned page in *Hunter* serves as a good example, where the text at the topmost frame explains the thoughts of the character: “Killua is suppressing the desire to ask: ‘Where are we heading?’ He realizes that it is inappropriate to raise a question like this given the current circumstance, but he has a strong feeling...” Here, the use of text as narration assumes an intricate balance between its marginality and authority, appearing supplementary to the image while also offering a canonical explanation.

However, in the non-essential space, text presents itself as an object-like entity that surpasses its marginal and canonical function. In the example of *Hunter*, as one descends the page, the text box disappears while the text continues in the dark panel below, shifting the perspective of narration to the character's internal spiritual world, as the third-person pronoun disappears: "If this question is raised, there is no going back..." The disappearance of the text box and pronoun suggests that the text is no longer marginal or descriptive; rather, it becomes tangible or even object-like with a materiality indifferentiable from its surrounding plane. Benjamin H. D. Buchloh argues in his essay on Marcel Broodthaers' industrial poems that text acquires "the status of an object" through the deletion of its semantic dimension and the revitalization of its spatial dimension.⁴⁵ In this case, as the text merges with the textured dark frame both formally and metaphorically, its status as a semantic element changes as its surrounding space transitions from a site of installation to a containing facility with concrete materiality. Text, therefore, acquires a physical relationship with its space, no longer compositionally configured but rather held and contained.

As the third-person pronoun disappears, the voice behind the text also becomes ambiguous. While this may reflect common practice in the Japanese language where pronouns are sometimes omitted, this study argues that this neglect of pronouns is intentional, as it allows the text to assume both objecthood and subjecthood, transforming it into a sound-making facility. When discussing the representation of sound in manga, one might immediately think of the use of onomatopoeia, or *giseigo*, where words that phonetically mimic a particular sound are employed to accompany the depiction of an action. However, rather than centering on the mechanism of sound production, *giseigo* is more often employed as what Natsume calls a "sound metaphor"

⁴⁶ where the shape of the character is more significant than the sound it indicates. Thus, the text presents itself as an intermediate agency between language and image, transforming text into an entity that has mass and hardness and subsequently a silent, structural signifier.

Text as Sound Production

The use of text in the non-essential space, however, does not signify sound but rather mimics the physicality of sound through a physical act of speaking. In “The Value of Painting,” Isabelle Graw describes painting as a “quasi-person” with a “subject-like power” capable of initiating actions as an autonomous agency.⁴⁷ This autonomy applies to the non-essential space, where text is spoken by its containing facility. In *Hunter*, as the text in the dark section merges with its frame, its history of making becomes uncertain and cannot be simply equated to an act of insertion, or pictorial planning in general. Since the framed plane is a textured, object-like entity, text cannot function as an interface between the semantic and the pictorial nor between the representational and the physical, since the construction of the plane does not rely on these indexical relationships. Instead, the most suitable way for text to interact with such a physical entity is to transform itself into the vibration of air molecules, initiated through its container, where its relationship with the frame is established through an act of collision. A page in Clamp’s *Clover* demonstrates this act of speaking with lucid clarity: the vertical frames on the pages’ left illustrate the shapes of the mouth voicing the katakana characters on the right: “I love you” (アイシテル).⁴⁸ Hence, the text in the non-essential space attains both objecthood and subjecthood, as it is able to not only

acquire physical materiality by merging with the frame, but also initiate actions as its iteration becomes an act of speaking.

Conclusion

Through examining the three compositional elements in the non-essential space—blank space, frame, and text—it becomes evident that this space, while influenced by various pictorial and film traditions, proposes a new mode of looking towards narrative compositions. Its construction and interpretation center on *material time*, a temporality derived from observing the space's physical structure and materiality. By emphasizing the object-like status of the pictorial elements, the non-essential space not only relieves the medium of manga from its fast-consumed nature but also presents an alternative conception of time in manga studies's mode of analysis. Through emphasis on the notion of material time, this essay builds prior discourse regarding the medium's engagement with time. It proposes a systematic evaluation that repositions temporality as a tactile experience rather than rejecting temporal readings. As readers' interactions with spatial compositions in manga shift from reading to touching, the non-essential space suggests an active yet enclosed space-time. It withholds emotive forces and invites viewers to experience space as spectacular occurrences and re-occurrences that exist through a temporal encounter centered on interaction, imagination, and memory.

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